SIGNAL OFFICER ADVANCE COURSE • BLOCK 1.5

Ethical Leadership and Transformational Leadership

Leading with Character in Military Organizations

Learning Objectives

TERMINAL LEARNING OBJECTIVE

At the end of the session, students will be able to analyze ethical and transformational leadership principles in military organizations.

ENABLING LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. **1.5.1**
   Apply ethical leadership principles in decision making.

2. **1.5.2**
   Analyze ethical decision making in leadership.

3. **1.5.3**
   Apply transformational leadership principles.

Session Roadmap

1.5.1	Ethical Leadership in Military Operations	15 min
1.5.2	Ethical Decision Making	20 min
1.5.3	Leadership Integrity	15 min
1.5.4	Transactional vs. Transformational Leadership	20 min
1.5.5	Transformational Leadership in Military Units	20 min
EVAL	Assessment: Essay + Scenario Response	20 min

References

1. FM 6-22 (FM 22-100), Army Leadership: Competent, Confident, and Agile
2. ADP 6-22, Army Leadership and the Profession
3. Bass, B. M., & Riggio, R. E. (2006). Transformational Leadership (2nd ed.). Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.
4. AFP Code of Ethics and Code of Conduct for AFP Personnel

1.5.1

Ethical Leadership in Military Operations

What Is Ethical Leadership?

Ethical leadership is leading in a manner consistent with the Army Ethic and Army Values — especially when it is inconvenient, costly, or unobserved.

- Grounded in Army Values — Honor, Patriotism, Duty — as the moral foundation for decisions and relationships
- Tested most under pressure: combat, austere conditions, resource shortages, time constraints
- Not just personal virtue — it shapes unit climate, subordinate trust, and mission legitimacy

KEY IDEA

Ethics is not what a leader does when being watched.

It is what a leader does when no one is.

Why It Matters in Operations

1

Mission Legitimacy

Operations conducted within ethical and legal bounds preserve the Army's moral authority to act.

2

Force Cohesion

Soldiers follow leaders they trust to act rightly, especially under fire or scarcity.

3

Long-Term Readiness

Ethical lapses (falsified reports, shortcuts) create risks that surface later — often in combat.

The fog of war does not suspend the Army Ethic — it magnifies the need for it.

Scenario: COMSEC Under Pressure

SITUATION

During a prolonged field exercise, a Signal company is behind schedule establishing the unit's communications network. A subordinate suggests bypassing a required encryption-key changeover to save time and “catch up.” The company commander is under pressure from higher headquarters to report the network as fully operational.

DISCUSSION

What does ethical leadership require of this commander — and what does it cost to uphold it here?

1.5.2

Ethical Decision Making

The Ethical Decision-Making Process

1 Define the Problem

Identify the ethical dilemma — what values or duties are in tension?

2 Know the Rules

Identify applicable laws, regulations, orders, and Army Values at stake.

3 Develop Courses of Action

Generate feasible options, not just the first one that comes to mind.

4 Evaluate Each COA

Test each option against legal, moral, and practical (mission) considerations.

5 Decide and Act

Choose the course of action and take responsibility for it.

6 Reflect

Assess the outcome and what it teaches for future decisions.

Three Ethical Lenses

Rules-Based

Is it lawful and within regulations and orders?

AFP Code of Ethics · UCMJ / Articles of War · SOPs

Outcomes-Based

What result best accomplishes the mission and protects the force?

Weigh consequences for soldiers, mission, unit

Virtue-Based

What would a leader of strong character do?

Army Values · Honor · Patriotism · Duty

Applying the Process: Signal Corps

SITUATION

A commander discovers a subordinate bypassed the required encryption-key changeover during the earlier exercise to save time, and the network report submitted upward states the unit is “fully COMSEC compliant.”

- Problem: A false compliance report exists; unit security posture is misrepresented.
- Rules: COMSEC SOPs, AFP Code of Ethics, integrity of official reports.
- COAs: Say nothing / quietly correct it internally / report and correct through the chain.
- Decision: Report and correct — protects the force even at reputational cost.

Applying the Process: General Scenario

SITUATION

During a live-fire exercise, a platoon leader realizes a near-miss friendly-fire incident occurred due to a coordination error on their own part. No one was hurt, and no one else witnessed it. Reporting it accurately will trigger a safety investigation and reflect on the leader's record.

DISCUSSION

Walk through the six-step process. Which lens — rules, outcomes, or virtue — carries the most weight here, and why?

1.5.3

Leadership Integrity

Integrity: Consistency of Word and Deed

Integrity is doing what is right — legally and morally — even when it is difficult, and even when reporting the truth costs the unit or the leader personally.

- Alignment between values, words, and actions — subordinates watch what leaders do, not just what they say
- The foundation that makes every other attribute credible: empathy, discipline, and confidence mean little without it
- Built in small decisions long before it is tested in large ones

EXAMPLE

A company commander discovers missing equipment during inventory. Rather than concealing the discrepancy to protect the unit's reputation, the commander reports it accurately and initiates corrective action.

Scenario: Signal Equipment Inventory

SITUATION

A Signal company NCOIC discovers a discrepancy in communications equipment holdings during a scheduled inventory — several handheld radios are unaccounted for. Reporting it accurately will draw scrutiny during an already difficult evaluation period.

DISCUSSION

What signal does concealment send to the unit — and what signal does accurate reporting send? Which one builds long-term trust?

The Cost of Integrity Failures

1 Erosion of Trust

Subordinates stop believing what leaders tell them — trust, once broken, is slow to rebuild.

2 Mission Risk

Falsified readiness or status reports create hidden vulnerabilities that surface at the worst time.

3 Unit Cohesion

A climate that tolerates dishonesty at the top normalizes it throughout the ranks.

4 Accountability

Integrity violations carry legal and administrative consequences under military law and regulation.

1.5.4

Transactional vs. Transformational Leadership

Two Leadership Models

TRANSACTIONAL

- Leadership as an exchange: performance for reward or correction
- Contingent Reward — clear expectations, recognized when met
- Management-by-Exception (Active) — monitors and corrects deviations
- Management-by-Exception (Passive) — intervenes only after problems occur
- Maintains standards and discipline — necessary, but rarely inspiring

TRANSFORMATIONAL

- Leadership as inspiration: raises followers' motivation beyond self-interest
- Builds commitment, not just compliance, to shared goals
- Defined by Bass & Riggio's Four I's (next slide)
- Develops followers into future leaders
- Produces performance beyond expectations

The Four I's of Transformational Leadership

I

Idealized Influence

Leading by example; a role model soldiers want to follow, not just obey.

I

Inspirational Motivation

Communicating a compelling vision and sense of purpose behind the mission.

I

Intellectual Stimulation

Encouraging soldiers to question assumptions and innovate on problems.

I

Individualized Consideration

Coaching and mentoring each soldier according to their needs and potential.

Side-by-Side Comparison

DIMENSION	TRANSACTIONAL	TRANSFORMATIONAL
Focus	Structured exchange — reward for performance	Shared vision — inspiration beyond self-interest
Source of Motivation	External — reward, correction, standards	Internal — purpose, identity, growth
Leader's Role	Enforcer of standards and procedures	Role model, mentor, and visionary
Typical Outcome	Reliable compliance and discipline	Initiative, commitment, performance beyond expectations

Signal Corps: Same Task, Two Approaches

TRANSACTIONAL APPROACH

The commander enforces the preventive maintenance schedule for commo equipment strictly — tracks completion, issues corrective counseling for missed checks, and ties results to evaluation ratings. Equipment readiness meets standard.

TRANSFORMATIONAL APPROACH

The commander explains why network resilience protects soldiers' lives in contact, invites the platoon to propose improvements, and a junior NCO's idea becomes a standardized digital equipment-status reporting system — readiness exceeds standard, and the unit sustains it without being told to.

1.5.5

Transformational Leadership in Military Units

The Four I's Applied at Unit Level

Idealized Influence

Commander maintains COMSEC discipline personally, even when no one is checking — soldiers follow the example, not just the order.

Inspirational Motivation

Commander frames encryption discipline as “protecting the soldier on the ground,” not just compliance — giving the standard meaning.

Intellectual Stimulation

Commander invites platoons to propose improvements to equipment-status reporting — innovation becomes routine, not exceptional.

Individualized Consideration

A platoon leader privately supports a soldier through a family crisis, adjusting duties while maintaining unit effectiveness.

Case: Mentorship and Innovation in a Signal Company

SITUATION

A Signal company experiences repeated delays reporting communications equipment failures. Rather than simply directing faster reporting, the commander mentors junior officers, explains the operational cost of delayed reporting, and empowers a junior officer to design a standardized digital status-reporting system. Platoons adopt it and situational awareness improves markedly.

- Individualized Consideration: developing a junior officer's initiative, not just assigning a task
- Intellectual Stimulation: the fix came from the ranks, not a directive from the top
- Result: faster maintenance coordination, and an officer who now leads with more confidence

Case: Joint Task Force in Disaster Response

SITUATION

During a humanitarian assistance and disaster response (HADR) operation, a joint task force commander leads Signal, engineer, and infantry elements working under exhausting conditions with unclear command relationships. The commander repeatedly frames the mission around the affected community rather than unit boundaries, personally works alongside troops, and publicly credits units for successes.

- Inspirational Motivation: a shared purpose overrides inter-unit friction
- Idealized Influence: commander's visible effort earns followership across units, not just within one chain of command
- Result: sustained cooperation and morale despite fatigue and ambiguity

The Augmentation Effect

Bass & Riggio's research finding: transformational leadership does not replace transactional leadership — it augments it. Units need both the structure of clear standards and the inspiration of shared purpose.

+

Unit Cohesion

+

Soldier Initiative

+

Operational Resilience

+

Retention & Morale

Key Takeaways

- Ethical leadership is the moral foundation for every decision a leader makes — tested most under operational pressure
- The ethical decision-making process (FM 6-22 / ADP 6-22) gives leaders a repeatable method for sound judgment under ambiguity
- Integrity is what makes every other leadership attribute credible — it is built or broken in small decisions
- Transactional leadership maintains standards; transformational leadership inspires commitment beyond them — strong units need both
- Bass & Riggio's Four I's translate directly into everyday Signal Corps leadership behaviors, from COMSEC discipline to mentorship

EVALUATION

Assessment

PART A — ESSAY

Analyze how ethical leadership and transformational leadership principles complement each other in sustaining Army Values within a military unit. Support your analysis with FM 6-22 / ADP 6-22 principles, Bass & Riggio's framework, and one concrete example.

600–800 words.

PART B — SCENARIO RESPONSE

Given a Signal Corps leadership dilemma, apply the six-step ethical decision-making process and identify which of the Four I's the leader should draw on to resolve it and sustain unit trust.

2 scenarios, 150–250 words each.

Learning Outcome

By the end of this session, students are able to analyze ethical and transformational leadership principles in military organizations — and apply them as Signal officers.

End of Presentation

Questions & Discussion